

"THE MASTER KEY"

By John Fleming Wilson

REAL ESTATE

Real estate transfers filed with the county recorder Thursday are as follows:

Francesca Roth to Alice C. Roth, 1.39 acres in the Philander donation land claim; \$1.

Mary A. Baker to H. F. Baker, 47.41 acres in section 18, 15, township 2 south, range 1 east of Willamette meridian; \$1.

Charles L. Baker to Mary A. Baker, tract of land in sections 15 and 16, township 2 south, range 1 east of Willamette meridian; \$1.

August Erickson et ux. to J. H. Fischer, 3 acres in section 16, township 4 south, range 2 east of Willamette meridian; \$1.

Benjamin F. Hester et ux. to J. D. Cooley, 3.25 acres and 14.55 acres in township 2 south, range 4 east of Willamette meridian; \$1.

Real estate transfers filed with the county recorder Saturday are as follows:

George C. Johnson et ux. to Edwin Palmer et ux., tracts 27 and 72, Peach Cove; \$10.

Pearl M. Hoyt et ux. to Fringale Shaw, 6.426 acres in Tract "E" "The Shaver Place"; \$1200.

H. E. Lupton to John M. Griffith, 480 acres in section 35, township 2 south, range 5 east of Willamette meridian; \$1.

W. A. Proctor et ux. to F. W. Caniney, tract of land in Clackamas county; \$1.

Real estate transfers filed with the county recorder Monday are as follows:

D. N. Trullinger to Herbert A. Trullinger, 50 acres in section 28, township 4 south, range 2 east of Willamette meridian; \$100.

W. M. Laod et ux. to Ida Heighon, lots 5, 9 and 10, W. M. Laod's subdivision of tract 15, of Hedges addition to Oregon City; \$750.

David E. Pendleton et ux. to B. C. Palmer, 40 acres in section 17, township 5 south, range 2 east of Willamette meridian; \$1.

Elizabeth S. Seale et ux. to H. J. Watt, 10 acres in section 22, township 4 south, range 4 east of Willamette meridian; \$10.

Joe Drough, of Molalla, was in town the first of the week on his way home after spending several weeks in a Portland hospital where he received treatment for a broken arm. He has recovered from the injury.

Mr. and Mrs. John I. Wilmer, of Hubbard, were in Oregon City Tuesday to attend to business matters.

Real estate transfers filed with the county recorder Tuesday are as follows:

George T. Parry et ux. to Pauline Ausicker, tract of land in the Witchia Tracts; \$125.70.

Gladstone Real Estate association to G. L. Clark et ux., lot 6, block 57, Gladstone; \$10.

Sabina P. Howlett to Emil L. Hollander, 23 1/2 acres in section 3 township 5 south, range 4 east of Willamette meridian; \$4200.

James N. Brasseale et al. to Frank S. Senn et ux., 80 acres in section 24, township 1 south, range 2 east of Willamette meridian; \$10.

J. W. Miller et ux. to George A. Miller, lot 4, block 57, 1st addition to Esplanade; \$300.

William Welch et ux. to Maurice L. Gottwald, 19 acres in section 2, township 5 south, range 1 east of Willamette meridian; \$1600.

Peter J. Roeder et ux. to Bracher Timber Co., 160 acres section 14, township 7 south, range 4 east of Willamette meridian; \$1.

Bracher Timber Co. to Peter J. Roeder, 160 acres in section 14, township 7 south, range 4 east of Willamette meridian; \$1835.

Real estate transfers filed with the county recorder Wednesday are as follows:

Lulu M. Campbell et al. to Amanda E. Hyde, lot "B", tract 37, Willamette Tracts; \$1.

Linda Holladay Dorey to Continental Realty and Improvement Co., tract of land in section 29, township 1 south, range 2 east of Willamette meridian; \$10.

Ben H. Dorey to Continental Realty & Improvement Co., tract of land in section 33, township 1 south, range 2 east of Willamette meridian; \$1.

Oregon Iron & Steel Co. to the public, tract of land through lot 23, Rosewood, for road purposes.

Anna Johnson et vir. to Christian A. Johnson, 80 acres in section 20, township 3 south, range 5 east of Willamette meridian; \$600.

D. T. Trullinger et ux. to L. Pauline Zwifal, tract of land in section 28, township 4 south, range 2 east of Willamette meridian; \$1800.

George T. Smith et ux. to John H. Mitchell, 5 acres in section 17, township 2 south, range 5 east of Willamette meridian; \$10.

William W. Sneed to W. W. Elliott, 6 2/3 acres in section 6, township 4 south, range 1 east of Willamette meridian; \$833.65.

R. C. McDaniels et ux. to Molalla Electric Co., 4 acres in section 6, township 4 south, range 1 east of Willamette meridian; \$50.

Hurlbut Returns. PORTLAND, Ore., Dec. 24.—C. M. Hurlbut, representative-elect from the Multnomah-Clackamas joint district, returned to Portland today from an eastern trip, and promptly began a determined effort to retain the seat in the legislature to which he has been elected.

Hurlbut was the regular Republican nominee, but was repudiated by the Republican organization in both counties, comprising his district. In spite of this circumstance Hurlbut was elected by a majority of more than 2000, votes over Roscoe P. Hurst, the regular Democratic nominee, who was openly supported by many Republicans. Hurst proposes to file a contest for the seat with the secretary of state.

Douglas Attorney Named. SALEM, Ore., Dec. 24.—Governor West today appointed George Neuner, of Roseburg, district attorney of Douglas county, to succeed George Brown, who will become attorney general January 1.

Logging operations will continue all winter on South Inlet, Coos Bay.

CHAPTER XI.

Sing Wah and His Wife.

JOHN DORR stood stupidly staring at the papers which he had found in the locked drawer of the dresser. His brief inquiries at the desk had only served to make the matter darker, so he had come back to the room to puzzle things out.

Painfully he set the facts in order before him. The first was that Ruth had gone to New York to deal with Everett about money for improvements to the "Master Key." The second was that she had evidently not been able to find Everett and had started west again. The third was that she had been in this very room. There lay the papers that represented the mine and its value. But how—where—how could it be?

His businesslike senses returned, and he proceeded to wire Everett's office in New York, with the result that he was soon in possession of his address in San Francisco.

"So Everett's here, too," he muttered. "That is stranger yet. I guess it was time I dropped in. Now to find Ruth!"

He thrust the packet of papers in his pocket and then withdrew them and looked them again into the dresser drawer. He had a dim notion that Ruth might come back for them. Then he telephoned to the St. Francis hotel and left word for Everett, who was reported to be out.

Still following what his common sense told him was the logical method of unraveling the tangle he went down to the desk and entered into conversation with the clerk. Meanwhile his eye ran down the register. Opposite the number of the room he now occupied he saw a heavily scribbled "Mrs. J. Darnell and daughter."

He frowned, and the clerk said sympathetically, "You must have a nasty headache."

"I have," John returned. "Met with an accident in an auto that rather upset me." He laid his finger on the register and, controlling his voice, went on as if casually, "I see Mrs. Darnell stops here."

To Dor's secret amazement the clerk became mysterious, leaning across the desk to whisper, "Ah, you know her?" "I wanted specially to see her," John equivocated. "Is she here?"

"She is not, and she left in a very strange way," the clerk explained quietly. "She came here last evening with her daughter. I gave them the room you have now. Along in the late hours she suddenly came down with the girl unconscious and told me that

"Do you know Mrs. Darnell very well?" she had been taken very ill and she was hurrying her to a hospital. There were a couple of men with her, and the house detective didn't like the looks of the whole affair, so he followed them."

"Was the girl very fair haired—and beautiful?" Dor managed to ask in an indifferent tone.

"Precisely," responded the clerk, suddenly matching his guest's manner. "If you want to find Mrs. Darnell maybe the house detective got her address—or the address of the hospital they took the girl to."

Presently, in response to a summons, appeared the detective, who scanned John's somewhat bruised face thoughtfully, saying nothing until the clerk explained that Mr. Dor wished, if possible, to get into communication with Mrs. Darnell.

"The best I can do is to find the taxi driver for you," he said slowly, still studying John's stalwart figure. "He may be out on the stand now. Let's see."

As they passed out the detective continued hesitatingly, "Do you know Mrs. Darnell very well?"

There was that in the man's tone that made John pause before answering. He glanced at the cool, impassive face and caught the glint of the steady eyes. He took a sudden resolution.

"I believe you're really interested in this matter," Dor said briefly. "Suppose we talk this over before hunting the taxi chauffeur."

"I was merely curious, that's all," was the noncommittal murmur.

"That girl is not her daughter," John continued. "I have reason to believe that it is Miss Ruth Gallon, the heiress to the 'Master Key' mine, whom she is abducting." His passion blazed forth in spite of his self-restraint. "I must find her and save her."

"Might I ask what relation you are

to the young lady?" asked the detective mildly. John stared at him and then realized the oddity of his actions and words. He briefly explained his position at the mine and his wardship of the heiress. He also went into detail as to what he suspected Wilkerson of, describing him carefully.

"He was one of them, sure enough," agreed the detective. "But young heiresses ain't being kidnaped days like these out of hotels like this."

"I may be mistaken," John assented wearily. "All I know of Mrs. Darnell is from occasional words dropped by Wilkerson. But I suppose we might get a clue as to where they went away."

After some search of the long line of taxis they came to one which the detective identified as the one Mrs. Darnell had taken the night before.

"Driver, take us where you did those fares who were in such a hurry last night," the detective ordered.

The chauffeur shook his head. "You can search me for the address," he returned. "There wasn't any."

The driver leaned out from his seat and went on earnestly: "You know how they jumped in and we rolled off. Well, it seemed it was a case of life and death, according to the woman, and I stepped on the machine and hastened some toward the North Pacific hospital. But when we got into Chinatown one of the men hailed me and told me to drive just as he said. He got out here in front with me, and when we reached a certain spot they all beat it."

"Can you take us to that spot?" "I was just wondering to myself whether I could find it," was the response. "But I'll try."

He threw in his clutch and the car left the line and started up the hill toward California street. John Dor leaned back against the cushions with a strange sense of at last being on his way toward his goal. He barely heard his companion's murmur, "Evidently they took her into the lower part of Chinatown."

They usually credit the oriental with little or no imagination, pointing to his art, his clothes and his language as evidences. As the fact runs, even the Chinese could use the faculty of imagination more frequently than his white brother on an equal social plane.

Sing Wah, or Wah Sing, as he was indifferently called, was outwardly a stolid, dull-eyed Chinese of uncertain middle age. His picture—it was in the gallery of every secret service office from Singapore to Philadelphia—was not less changeless of expression, nor more tectured than he. Yet in spite of his somber clothes and general air of blank stupidity, Sing Wah was a man of mark, a man with a history replete with adventure and not too seldom with crime.

If the ordinary criminal could have an office or a store he would quadruple his profits. But the common run of criminals must steal and fly. Their post-office address is a figment. They are not at home when opportunity knocks. Sing Wah knew this, and it was his boast that for thirty years any one who wanted him, either day or night, could find him.

So he sat at the back of his little store night after night, blinking through the wooden screen at the various customers who came in to trade or barter. And year after year they came to his door, the pirate and the thief, the smuggler and the robber, and he took his toll of them and passed them on. Whether Sing Wah never told. And because he did not tell they came back with greater loot and richer booty, and he again passed them through his store to vanish utterly from the haunts of men and the purview of the police.

Among the many hundreds who had availed themselves of Sing Wah's aid was Wilkerson, who, during dark periods of his career, had several times run athwart the barriers of the law and been compelled to seek refuge where he could.

Harry Wilkerson was not a fool. In some ways he was brilliantly endowed. He recognized Sing Wah's superiority to all others in the great game of outwitting the law. He perceived beneath the stolid mask the alert, active, studious mind which was ever vigilant, never forgetful, always intelligently watching the world that passed before his flamed eyes. The Chinese had, as well, acknowledged Wilkerson's adeptness and persistency. In several deals they had been partners to their mutual profit.

"You are a very good fellow, Harry," Sing Wah had told him once as they drank tea in a little room in the rear. "You are a smart man—almost as smart as I am. But you are too hungry. You cannot resist your appetites. Now, I—made a slight gesture of distaste with his lean brown hand—"I have no appetites."

Wilkerson nodded. "I guess you're right, Sing Wah. You even haven't any pride. You talk pidgin English to the tourists and the rest. Instead of speaking the perfect English you know."

The dull eyes lit for a moment humorously. "I have always felt that I owed it to Oxford not to flaunt my education in a small tradesman's shop, don't you know?"

The imitation of the Oxonian drawl had been so natural that Wilkerson had slapped his thighs in delight. Thereafter he took a peculiar pleasure in watching Sing Wah's assumed silent stupidity and comparing it with what he knew to be the real person behind the dull features.

It was to Wilkerson that the Chinese had explained his reason for never changing his address, no matter how brisk the police might be. "And I have thought out a scheme which you will like," he went on. "Come with me."

It was then that he showed Wilkerson the cylindrical room which had a single door and revolved at a touch on a lever.

"Dangerous stuff!" commented Wilkerson. "If the police find that they'll sure land you."

Sing Wah's pallid lips opened in faint smile. "I built it for them. And the Chinatown guides know about it and will charge \$10 extra for a trip through the horrors of the underground, as they call it." The Chinese sneered. "Let them play with such things while I use the brains heaven gave me. And yet, sometime that trick room may serve a purpose."

Thus it came about that Harry Wilkerson, driven to his wits' end to accomplish his designs, betrouthled him of Sing Wah and fairly drove Jean Darnell and Drake before him.

To Mrs. Darnell's credit it must be said that she rebelled strongly. But

the stake was too great to risk, and she bitterly consented to Wilkerson's hastily outlined plan of hiding Ruth away somewhere in Sing Wah's precincts until they could once more get their plans into working order.

Before she would leave the place she must indeed see Sing Wah himself. "Will the girl be safe here?" she demanded.

The Chinese looked at her flushed and passionate beauty in silence until she repeated her question. Then he said quietly and in his own exquisite modulated English: "You need have little fear. The servants are honest and discreet. And—he let his eyes meet hers fully—"I think it is possible that she is safer now than she has been for some time. Good night, madam."

While Wilkerson and Mrs. Darnell had been hurriedly arranging matters with Sing Wah, Drake had gone in search of lodgings nearby. He found them in what had once been a noted hotel, which had fallen into sad decay. It was in the faded rooms he engaged here that the three met to consult on the future.

"The first thing to do is to get hold of those deeds and papers she has in her grip," said Wilkerson. "I wonder you didn't think to get them before, Jean."

The woman's eyes lit with dull hatred, but she made no answer. She watched him fuss with the locks of the hand satchel which she had indicated as the one in which Ruth carried her valuables. When it opened and Wilkerson thrust his clutching fingers downward into it Mrs. Darnell leaned forward as if in protest. He paid no attention to her, but continued his search with ever increasing haste. At last he straightened up with an oath so venomous and deadly that even Drake shrank back.

"The deeds aren't here," Wilkerson said thickly. "She's hidden them!" "But where?"

This question seemed to break Wilkerson's almost steely intensity of purpose. The question put his whole problem before him in two words—but where? He shifted his eyes from the emptied satchel to the curtained window. Instantly there leaped before him the picture of the truck turning slowly over in the gulch, of the huge billow of smoke, of the little lances of fire that charged through the dry undergrowth as if to preserve to the flames their prey. Was it for this that he was a murderer? The curtain blew inward before some vagrant wind from the bay, and Wilkerson drew back in terror.

"What is it, Harry?" demanded Mrs. Darnell, instantly taking alarm. "Nothing," he said sullenly. "I was just thinking of something." He turned on Drake. "You've got to do the trick," he went on. "How's that?" demanded the young man.

Wilkerson eagerly formulated his plan, ticking off the points on the tips of his quivering fingers. "First you've got to turn up at last. You find her?"

"In Chinatown!" sneered Drake. "You can easily gain her confidence and get hold of the papers, and maybe—"

Drake laughed ugly. "I look like the kind of joker who would dress up as a banker and then proceed to renew my client's acquaintance in a Chinese joint. How am I supposed to know she's there? I tell you, Wilkerson, that you can't travel straight, even when it pays you. Why in God's name you ever took that girl to that place of Sing Wah's is beyond my comprehension. Any place would have been better. Now you have put the heads of all of us in a noose. You know what people will say when—"

"They'll say nothing," said Wilkerson furiously, and he proceeded once more to argue that Drake could easily continue to impersonate Everett and in that guise carry their scheme to its profitable conclusion. In spite of his eagerness and sophistry he was unable to move either Drake or Mrs. Darnell from their attitude of frightened contempt. At last Drake agreed to do his best to make Ruth trust him.

"But I don't like this impersonation business," he said firmly. "I might go to a hotel and hand in my broker's card and ask for an interview, but I haven't lost my senses."

"Well," growled Wilkerson, "just see to it that you worm out of her where those papers are."

Drake grunted. "I'll see to it."

He looked at his watch. "It's late. I'll see you tomorrow."

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CHAPTER XII.

Crossed Wires.

THIS it happened that just when Drake entered Sing Wah's unpretentious doorway the taxi with the hotel detective and John Dor drew up in a side street and stopped.

"It was here they left me," said the chauffeur sulkily.

The detective and John got out and stared about them. They were in the lower part of Chinatown, a single tier of blocks that stretched beyond the bounds toward the bay—not in the quarter, but of it.

"Which way did they take the girl?" said the practical detective.

The driver led them around the corner and up an alleyway. He pointed to Sing Wah's door. "I think they went in there," he muttered.

"Ah!" said the detective thoughtfully. "When I was on the police force I used to know that Chinaman. He's the smoothest rascal in America, bar none."

John gritted his teeth in helpless rage. "And she's in that fiend's foul clutches," he growled aloud.

At this moment a policeman came along and accosted John's companion familiarly. In a few words the case was explained to him.

"You won't find anything, of course," the officer remarked. "But just for satisfaction let's have a look-see and a chin-chin with Sing Wah."

They entered the shop just as a Chinese was closing a panel door after Drake, who had come to make his promised attempt to win Ruth's confidence. Sing Wah was nowhere to be seen.

After some futile parley with the Chinese, whose ignorance was complete in every detail, the two officers agreed that they were wasting time.

"Old Sing's the boy to see," said the house detective. "Let's wait awhile."

Now, Sing Wah had pondered the affair during the night, and the more he thought over having a lovely white-girl in the cylindrical room the less he liked it. It was deadly dangerous. Courts might be lenient with the smuggler and the go-between. Sing Wah knew that if even a suspicion got abroad that a young white woman was imprisoned in his quarters a ravening mob would tear his place stick from stone and hang him without trial. He was determined to get the girl away immediately. So he was unforgoingly glad to see Drake.

Drake attempted to explain what Wilkerson wanted, but the Chinese cut him short.

"Harry is insane," he said quietly. "He is mad over that woman. I have done all I can. You must get her out of here."

"But how?" demanded Drake. "She doesn't know me very well, and she'll scream her head off, and I'll be arrested, and we'll all be in a mess."

Sing Wah nodded thoughtfully. Then he looked up and listened to the low words of one of his clerks. Dismissing him with a single grunt, he turned to Drake.

"There's not much time," he said softly. "They are on the trail already."

"Who?"

"The police," he motioned Drake to a chair in the little alcove, where they stood and went on: "Stay here a moment. I will see for myself."

He pulled a lever, and the room swung around till the door was opposite him. With long, slender fingers he slipped back the panel and vanished.

Ruth lay on a couch, open-eyed and white-faced. Beside her a richly dressed Chinese woman crouched, whisper-

ing under low arches till she felt a sudden cool, salt breath on her face. At her feet she saw the glimmer of water and a boat riding to a long palanquin. Quickly and silently Sing Wah drew the little craft alongside and motioned to her to get in.

By this time the tumult had died down to a mere muttering of shots with an occasional yell, muffled by walls and the distance. She stared fearfully about her, at the great arches of dripping brick overhead, at the little landing under foot, at the dark vista of the tunnel through which the water streamed in a swirling tide. She drew back and let her voice out in one long, forlorn scream, the pent up agony of many hours, her final call for help against the dark powers that had seized upon her.